at least to the armchair strategists in London – that the two empires would at some point come into collision in central Asia. Lord Ellenborough, the hawkish new President of the Company's Board of Control, and minister with responsibility for India in the Duke of Wellington's Cabinet, was the first to turn this growing anxiety into public policy. 'Our policy in Asia must follow one course only,' he wrote in his diary, 'to limit the power of Russia.' Later he added: 'Four months from leaving Khiva the enemy might be at Kabul. The Directors are much afraid . . . [but] I feel confident we shall have to fight the Russians on the Indus and I have long had a presentiment that I should meet them there, and gain a great battle.'[46]

Ellenborough, the son of Warren Hastings's defence lawyer, was a brilliant but difficult and unappealing man, whose physical appearance, dominated by what one observer called 'his horrid grey locks', was so distasteful that George IV was alleged to have claimed that the very sight of Ellenborough made him sick. He suffered a crushing humiliation when his first wife, the beautiful but wayward Jane Digby, left him and took a succession of lovers, first the Austrian Prince Schwarzenberg, with whom Ellenborough fought a duel, then in quick succession the kings of both Bavaria and Greece, and an Albanian general, before ending up happily married to a Bedouin sheikh in Palmyra. The ridicule Ellenborough suffered as a result permanently marked his character and led to him retreating into a cocoon of pride and ambition. But, for all his arrogance, he was energetic and clever, and became the first British politician to build a career on opposition to Russian imperialism.[47]

Though Ellenborough exaggerated the threat to the British dominions in India – St Petersburg had in reality no plans to attack the British there – it was certainly true that Russia had recently shown itself extremely aggressive in its dealings with Ottoman Turkey and Qajar Persia. Only a year after Napoleon's 1812 retreat from Moscow, the Russian artillery had massacred Fatteh Ali Shah Qajar's Persian army, and proclaimed the 'liberation' of the Eastern Christians of Armenia and Georgia. Russia then annexed great swathes of modern Armenia and Azerbaijan – what had been until then the Persian Empire in the Caucasus. 'Persia was delivered, bound hand and foot, to the Court of St Petersburg,' wrote the British Ambassador to Teheran.[48]

This turned out to be only the first of a long series of Ottoman and Persian defeats which marked the Russian army's relentless advance southwards.[49]